

Arbaeen Walk – a life-changing journey of love

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Millions of ardent lovers, in an exhibition of unfathomable love and devotion for their beloved, walk seamlessly and untiringly from one sacred city to another, day and night, braving inclement weather and ominous security threats. Men and women, young and old, they come from different corners of the world and converge at one place. They call it heaven.

It is not an excerpt from a gripping page-turner, loaded with figments of imagination. It is a beautiful miracle I saw unfold before my eyes last year. A miracle that convinced me that miracles still take place. A miracle that recurs every year, with whole world watching in awe.

If you haven't guessed yet, I am talking about the largest and the greatest rally against terrorism and extremism that takes place in the second lunar month, forty days from Ashura, which marks the martyrdom of Imam Hussain (as) and his followers in the desert plains of Karbala 14 centuries ago.

It's not merely a walk. It is a mark of protest against all forms and manifestations of terrorism, fascism, imperialism, despotism, and oppression perpetuated by state and non-state actors. It is a rallying cry in support of the oppressed, weak and powerless. It is a reaffirmation of pledge to uphold the principles exemplified by the 'master of challengers' in Karbala.

The journey of a lifetime

Arbaeen walk takes place from Najaf to Karbala – from the final resting place of the 'leader of faithful' to that of the 'master of martyrs'. It is a journey of love.

Last year I was blessed with an opportunity to embark on this life-changing journey. It was the fulfillment of a long-cherished dream. I had heard fascinating stories from those who went before me. I had also watched video documentaries and read articles and travelogues about it. Now it was time to live the dream.

As a journalist, my work requires me to travel extensively. After long stints in New Delhi and Kabul, last year my work brought me to Tehran. The move filled me with joy because Iran had always been on my wish-list. But what made it all the more special was the realization that I was now a step closer to that sacred land. I could sense the pull and hear the calling. The long, agonizing wait was coming to an end. And what better time than Arbaeen.

Exactly a week before Arbāeen, I grabbed my backpack and boarded a bus at Tehran bus terminal for Shalamchēh, a border town in western Khuzestan province. The bus reached border in the wee hours of morning. It was totally chaotic with tens of thousands jostling for space to enter Iraq by foot. I had never seen such scenes in my life. All of them were visibly excited for the journey ahead. The chants of '*Ya Hussain*' filled the air, as sun peeked slowly over the desert horizon.

It was a long wait at the border, but nobody seemed to complain, because it was worth it. I stood in a queue for about three hours before I could cross over. The moment I stepped on the soil of Iraq, I had goose-bumps. The feeling was overwhelming and the calling was louder now. I had finally made it.

After a walk of few kilometers in 'no-man's land' that divides the two countries, I boarded another bus on the Iraqi side of border to Najaf. It was a long and arduous journey in a bus teeming with pilgrims but the excitement and eagerness to reach the destination overshadowed everything. All minds and eyes were glued to the golden dome of Imam Ali (as) mausoleum in Najaf. Despite weariness, no one slept on the way. When the bus finally reached the terminal in Najaf, it was dreamlike. We were in the city of the 'commander of the faithful'.

Prelude to the walk

In Najaf, streets were teeming with pilgrims who had flocked from different parts of the world. Local people had set up stalls, serving visitors sweetened drinks, fruits and snacks. I had heard about the hospitality of Iraqis and now I was witnessing the same. As I made my way through the crowd, two young boys who sensed that I was a foreigner offered to host me in Najaf. It was a beautiful gesture from complete strangers with whom the only relation I had was love for Ahlulbayt (as). We happened to be devotees of the man who was known in Kufa as the 'father of orphans' for his nobility and large-heartedness.

I politely asked them to excuse me because one of my school-time friends in India, now a student at Najaf seminary, was waiting for me. The food stalls were all around me, served with love and warmth, but somehow my hunger had fizzled out. I just wanted to reach the shrine of Imam Ali (as). It was a walking distance from the terminal and I walked as briskly as I possibly could. The crowd kept growing

around me and my pace diminished. It seemed the whole world had converged there.

There are many small, winding lanes around the shrine and all of them were crammed with people. After much hard work, I reached a point from where I could see the beautiful golden dome of the shrine. I momentarily stood still and had a long look at it. This was the moment I had waited for so long.

Another struggle was going inside the shrine. I stood at the gate and a wave of people came until I found myself in the main hall of the magnificent shrine. Tears yelled from my eyes irrepressibly. Here I was, in the city of my Imam, inside his shrine, under his dome, in front of his resting place. I wanted to believe what I was seeing, feeling and experiencing. I wanted to believe that it was real, not a dream. I wanted to believe that I had been honored by him to visit him.

Inside the shrine I saw people crying, screaming, smiling, beaming – a whole range of pure, genuine emotions. ‘Ya Ali’ was reverberating from all sides, a chant that has a universal appeal, a slogan you associate with the campaigners of truth and justice everywhere.

My two days in Najaf gave me a lifetime of memories to cherish. I stayed at my friend’s house close to the shrine but my host was Amiral Momineen (as) himself. I felt at home. I never felt that way anywhere else, until I reached Karbala.

The walk to heaven

It was finally time to head towards the land that we had heard about, read about, thought about. The land soaked in the blood of 72 martyrs, including the grandson of the apostle of God (pbuh). Whenever the talk veers to Karbala, our eyes become moist. With these tears, as Imam Khomeini (ra) said, we have razed to ground powerful empires.

Karbala is an idea, a concept and a movement that will always have significance and relevance. Imam’s uprising in those desert plains should strengthen our resolve to speak truth to power, to be the voice of voiceless, to campaign for truth and justice. As Dr. Ali Shariati says, martyrs gave their blood, now survivors have to carry the message of that blood to future generations. Imam Hussain (as) gave blood and Hazrat Zainab (sa) became an eloquent tongue of that blood.

Arbaeen walk is an endeavor that seeks to keep alive the movement of Karbala, to convey the message of blood to future generations. It is a movement against terrorism, fascism and despotism. It is a movement that seeks to safeguard and promote human values of love and compassion and condemn bigotry, tyranny and exploitation of powerful elites. It is a movement for humanity and its appeal cuts across the barriers of religion, caste, color and creed, which is precisely why non-Shias or for that matter even non-Muslims join this greatest march on earth.

For one week prior to Arbaeen, every day tens of thousands start the walk towards Karbala from Najaf. We began our walk three days before Arbaeen from the compound of Imam Ali (as) shrine. The streets were swarming with people wearing black dresses, holding flags, banners and placards, and chanting 'Labbaik Ya Hussain'. It was not a dream anymore. I believed my eyes.

The whole journey of around 80 km (50 miles) from Najaf to Karbala is marked with 1400 poles, corresponding with the number of years that have passed since the tragic event of Karbala. It takes about two days and two nights to cover this stretch depending on the pace of walk and stoppages in between. When we started the walk, it was drizzling complemented by a gentle breeze. There were men and women, children and elderly people all around me, walking towards the same destination.

For the love of Hussain (as)

Along the way from Najaf to Karbala, stalls had been set up by local residents, charities, mosques and foreign aid groups to ensure no pilgrim goes hungry or thirsty. Cooks prepared vast quantities of stewed lamb, grilled fish, beans, fresh bread and rice. There were small makeshift tents lined with foam mattresses and woolen blankets for people to rest or sleep. For those tired, there were masseurs to give them quick and revitalizing massage. For shoes covered with dust, there were volunteers to polish them. There were also mobile bathrooms to have a quick shower and mobile ambulances in case of a medical emergency. And they charged absolutely nothing. Just for the love of Ahlulbayt (as).

In recent years, the rush of pilgrims on Arbaeen has gone up tremendously. A new record is broken and set each year, and last year the figure touched the staggering 15 million, even though the official figure was different. Last year's Arbaeen

pilgrimage was the first since Iraqi government declared thumping victory over ISIS but the security concerns were still there. In all these years, people have been going for this pilgrimage despite ISIS presence in the country, which is quite remarkable. Only those with unflinching faith and unshakeable conviction are capable of taking such huge risks. It is safe to suggest that this greatest protest against terrorism was a key factor in the downfall of ISIS in Iraq.

Security concerns, however, did not play on my mind. I spent two years in Afghanistan, reporting on daily incidents of violence perpetrated by Taliban and ISIS. It was normal for me. On the way I grabbed a flag with ‘Ya Abal Fazl’ in one hand and a placard related to my own bruised and bleeding homeland – Kashmir – in the other hand. I had a feeling of ‘jihad’ at that moment, like a soldier dressed up for the war. It was undoubtedly overwhelming with a sea of people walking, running, scampering, crawling towards the abode of Aba Abdillah (as).

I saw a young man carrying his elderly mother on his shoulders, which was heartwarming. I saw a father pushing a wheelchair with his physically impaired son on it. I saw a 3-year old girl standing on a bench in the middle of night offering sweets to the travelers. I saw families walking together, and a grandfather holding the hand of his granddaughter, singing soul-stirring elegies in the memory of the martyrs of Karbala.

Millions of people walking towards Karbala had different nationalities, came from different cultures, spoke different languages, but what united them here was their love for Ahlulbayt (as) and commitment to honor their memory. It was like small tributaries merging together to form a sea. They proudly held aloft flags of their respective countries and marched in unison. Majority of them were Iranians, but many of them also from Lebanon, Azerbaijan, Pakistan, India, Turkey, Syria, Indonesia, and some European countries.

I met two university students from Australia who had come all the way from Sydney to witness this spectacle. They had heard about it from friends and read articles in newspapers which prompted them to embark on the journey of love. “This is spectacular. I have never seen anything like this, such massive crowd and yet so well-organized,” he told me in our ‘walk the talk’. “Saudi authorities should learn from Iraqis how to manage such a big religious gathering.”

I bumped across people from different nationalities and we instantly hit it off. The conversations ranged from Iraq's successful fight against ISIS, America's war crimes in the region, the secret dalliance of Arab states with the Zionist regime, situation of religious minorities in South Asia, and the relevance of Karbala in our times. We walked and talked and discovered that we agreed on many things. We became friends and companions in the walk. This is how Arbaeen can be a perfect intellectual exercise and cultural exchange between people of various nationalities and cultures that come together for a common cause.

Hospitality and kindness redefined

On day one of the walk, we took couple of short little breaks to refresh and recharge our bodies for the journey ahead. Days were relatively hot and nights were extremely cold. At every step of the way, there were friendly hosts urging us to sit for a sweetened black Iraqi tea and snacks. These people have redefined the whole concept of hospitality, where a host takes honor in serving his guests who are complete strangers to him.

We stopped at one small stall where a 30-something husband and wife were serving tea and fresh dates to travelers. They belonged to a local village and worked in farms to earn money for livelihood. Serving the guests of Imam Hussain (as), the man told me, was a privilege for him. "I save money every month from my meager earnings and accumulate all the saving to spend them on Aba Abdillah's (as) guests on Arbaeen. I can starve myself to make sure pilgrims have no reason to complain." His words touched me deeply and it reflects the kind of unbreakable bond Shiites share with the holy family.

We continued on our journey until the night fell and then halted to sleep for some hours before resuming the walk. All tents were full and there was hardly any space to lie down. The night was dark and cold as we looked for shelter. Some young boys came from nowhere and offered us woolen blankets, which saved us from the potential cold stroke. A few meters away, an elderly man said something to us in Arabic that we didn't understand. Then he gestured towards a small roadside tent and led us inside. Luckily there was still some space left. It's amazing the way complete strangers show such kindness and compassion to you on this journey.

At the break of dawn, we woke up for prayers and then resumed the walk until afternoon prayers, with few hurried tea breaks in between. On the way, the buzz was electrifying as we inched closer to our destination. Iranian pilgrims recited Farsi elegies, Indians and Pakistanis recited Urdu dirges, pilgrims from Lebanon and Syria joined the chorus with Arabic latmias. All melodies combined to create a heartwarming ambience and set the tempo for our grand arrival in the city of Karbala.

Following afternoon prayers, we walked briskly, perhaps out of excitement. We started counting the number of poles we left behind until a big billboard appeared on the way: 'Welcome to Karbala' written in Arabic. My heart skipped a beat. Since childhood I had been reciting a supplication, five times a day, beseeching Allah to grant me the honor of visiting Karbala. That moment had arrived.

I was in Karbala but the shrines were still a few miles away. It was an unbelievable crowd, barely a space to breathe. But who wanted to breathe in Karbala, I told myself. I would proudly breathe my last in Bainul Haramian, in between the shrines of two brothers. Slowly, very slowly, the crowd moved forward until the shrine of Aba Abdillah (as) appeared before our eyes.

Welcome to Karbala

We were officially in heaven. Every thought disappeared from my mind. All I could think of was that fateful day 14 centuries ago when a small group of holy warriors confronted the army of a mighty empire. The scenes started appearing before my eyes. An infant being taken to the battlefield, a young man fighting like a seasoned warrior, a standard bearer going to fetch water from a nearby stream and never coming back, little children crying of thirst and the beloved grandson of the apostle of God (pbuh) crying out loud: 'Is there anyone to help me'.

The question was not directed at the soldiers of Yazid ibn Muawiya. Imam Hussain (as) expected no mercy from them. It was directed at his followers. It was directed at us. This march of millions from Najaf to Karbala every year is a response to that call, which still echoes in our hearts and minds.

As I stood in front of the shrine of the master of martyrs (as), time came to a grinding halt. There were people from all sides trying to get closer to the shrine. In

the crowd I lost my fellow companions I had befriended on the way to Karbala. But it hardly mattered now. I was standing next to Hussain ibn Ali (as). Everything else lost the meaning. I felt like a mighty warrior who had conquered the world.

With much difficulty, I made my way through the crowd into Bainul Haramian, a small space between brothers – Imam Hussain (as) and Abol Fazl Abbas (as). This is the epicenter of universe. I looked at Hussain (as) and then I looked at Abol Fazl (as), I felt as if they were sitting together and watching us. I had never felt so emotional in my life. It was my first visit to Karbala and here I was standing between the two brothers who changed the course of history with their unflinching faith and indomitable valor.

I walked inside the shrine of Imam Hussain (as), with a tornado of people, and saw it jam-packed. In one corner of the hall, I found a little space to stand and recite Ziyarat e Arbaeen. I didn't want to leave that hall. I wanted to make it my home.

Then I went to the shrine of Abol Fazl Abbas (as), the standard bearer of Karbala, whose name was enough to leave enemies in disarray. His death broke the back of Hussain (as). As I walked inside his shrine, I could see he still had the same aura. People screamed and cried 'Ya Abol Fazl', 'Ya Alamdar'. There was no eye that was not moist. One Iranian group recited a beautiful elegy inside the hall – *Alamdar nayamad* (The flagbearer did not return). When I was a child, my mother told me to say 'Ya Abol Fazl' if you are afraid of anything or if you sense any danger. I have done that all these years and I always felt at ease. Now I was inside the shrine of Abol Fazl, calling him, sharing my secrets, telling him about my ordeals. I know he listened.

The two days in Karbala were life-changing for me. I did not sleep at night. I sat in Bainul Haramain and looked at both the shrines whole night and made silent prayers. After two unforgettable days in Karbala I left for Kazmain Baghdad to see my ancestor, Imam Moosa Kazim (as). The crowd was less here and I spent a night in prayers at the shrine. The next day I left for Samarra to visit Imam Askari shrine, which brought back memories of that terrorist attack. Those terrorists, like Yazid, have no trace anymore. The shrine stands tall and mighty, more than ever before. From Samarra I took a bus to Mehran border crossing and returned to Iran.

Bottomline

The pilgrimage came to an end. The most beautiful 10 days of my life. Arbaeen walk has now become a part of my life. I look forward to going again this year. It is a pledge of allegiance to the beloved and only true lovers will understand the meaning of this pure, profound love.